

House of a Thousand Doors

HSE73-A

By Meena Alexander

This house has a thousand doors
the sills are cut in bronze
three feet high
to keep out snakes,
toads, water rats
that shimmer in the bald reeds
at twilight
as the sun burns down to the Kerala coast.

The roof is tiled in red
pitched with a silver lightning rod
a prow, set out from land's end
bound nowhere.
In dreams
waves lilt, a silken fan
in grandmother's hands
shell colored, utterly bare as the light takes her.

She kneels at each
of the thousand doors in turn
paying her dues.
Her debt is endless.
I hear the flute played in darkness,
a bride's music.
A poor forked thing
I watch her kneel in all my lifetime
imploring the household gods
who will not let her in.

Meena Alexander (1951-2018)

- She is an Indian American poet, scholar, and writer
- Meena Alexander was born Mary Elizabeth Alexander
- Born in Allahabad and raised in Kerala and Sudan
- The Statesman described her as "undoubtedly one of the finest poets of contemporary times"
- Themes- migration, trauma, reconciliation, memories, desire, identity, place, family, gender.

Family

- Her parents are originally from Travancore in Kerala
- Her paternal grandmother, Mariyamma, was got married at the age of 8
- Her paternal grandfather was a wealthy landlord
- Her maternal grandmother, Kunju, was the first woman to become a member of the legislative assembly in Travancore State.
- Her maternal grandfather was a theologian and social reformer who worked with Gandhi.
- Poetry Collections

- Atmospheric Embroidery (2018)
- Birthplace with Buried Stones (2013)
- Illiterate Heart (2002) - Open Book Award winner
- Novels
- Manhattan Music (1997)
- Nampally Road (1991)
- Prose works
- Fault Lines (1993)
- Poetics of Dislocation (2009)
- The Shock of Arrival: Reflections on Postcolonial Experience (1996))
- Critical Studies
- Women in Romanticism: Mary Wollstonecraft, Dorothy Wordsworth and Mary Shelley (1989)
- The Poetic Self: Towards a Phenomenology of Romanticism (1979)
- **Facts About the Poem**
- Published in 1988 as part of Alexander's poetry collection of the same name, *House of a Thousand Doors*
- The poem reflects Alexander's diasporic experiences, blending personal memory with critiques of colonialism and patriarchy

Themes

- **Colonialism and Postcolonial Identity:** The "house" symbolizes India's historical openness to foreign influences, which led to exploitation. The "thousand doors" critique the legacy of colonization and neocolonial brain drain 47.
- **Gender and Patriarchy:** The grandmother's endless kneeling at doors represents women's subjugation in a patriarchal society. Her "endless debt" critiques gendered obligations 45.

- **Displacement and Belonging:** The house's "lightning rod bound nowhere" mirrors the speaker's sense of cultural dislocation and longing for home
- alienation, nostalgia, rootedness, nowhere and identity crisis

MCQs

1. Where is the "House of a Thousand Doors" located?
a) Tamil Nadu Coast b) Goa Beach
c) Kerala Coast d) Bengal Coast
Answer: c) Kerala Coast
2. The sills in the House of a Thousand Doors are cut in...
a) Iron b) Bronze c) Silver d) Marble
Answer: B) Bronze
3. The roof of the House of a Thousand Doors is tiled in...
a) Blue b) Green c) Red d) Yellow

Answer: C) Red

4. Who kneels at each of the thousand doors in turn?

- a) The speaker's mother
- b) The speaker's sister
- c) The grandmother of the speaker
- d) A servant

Ans: c) The grandmother of the speaker

5. Who is described as a "poor forked thing" in the poem?

- a) The speaker's father
- b) The nation of India
- c) The grandmother of the poet
- d) The house itself

Ans: c) The grandmother of the poet

6. What does her grandmother carry?

- a) A brass lamp
- b) Prayer beads
- c) A silken fan
- d) A shawl

Ans: c) A silken fan

7. House of a Thousand Doors was published in the year...

- a) 1985
- b) 1988
- c) 1995
- d) 1971

Ans: b) 1988

8. House of a Thousand Doors was published in the collection...

- a) Illiterate Heart
- b) River and Bridges
- c) House of a Thousand Doors: Poems and Prose Pieces
- d) Birthplace with Buried Stones

Ans: c) House of a Thousand Doors: Poems and Prose Pieces

9. The HOUSE in the title metaphorically stands for...

- a) The poet's mind
- b) The diaspora experience
- c) India
- d) Multiculturalism

Ans: c) India

10. The theme of the poem

- a) Personal experience
- b) Colonial influence
- c) Gender discrimination
- d) All of the above

Ans: d) All of the above

11. All have the permission to enter the home except

- a) Snakes
- b) Toads
- c) water rats
- d) All of the above

Ans: d) All of the above

12. The roof of the house is described as

- a) Red
- b) Black
- c) Brown
- d) Thatched

Ans: Red

13. The poem abides the Indian concept of

- a) Ahimsa
- b) Karma
- c) Vasudaiva Kudumbakam
- d) Dharma

Ans: c) Vasudaiva Kudumbakam

14. The time mentioned in the poem

- a) Dawn
- b) Noon
- c) Twilight
- d) Midnight

Ans: c) Twilight

15. Where is the house located in the poem?

- a) Tamil Nadu Coast
- b) Goa Beach
- c) Kerala Coast
- d) Mumbai Harbor

Ans: c) Kerala Coast

16. In the second stanza, the house is compared to

- a) A fortress
- b) A ship
- c) A mountain
- d) A tree

Ans: B) A ship

17. The water creatures at twilight.

- a) Swim
- b) Dive
- c) Shimmer
- d) Glow

Ans: c) Shimmer

18. What is bound 'nowhere' in the poem?

- a) Mast
- b) Prow
- c) Anchor
- d) Sail

Ans: b) Prow

19. The term 'nowhere' is a peculiarity of

- a) Modernist poets
- b) Romantic poets
- c) Diasporic poets
- d) Surrealist poets

Ans: c) Diasporic poets

20. "Her debt is endless." Whose?

- a) The mother's
- b) The grandmother's
- c) The father's
- d) The speaker's

Ans: b) The grandmother's

21. What did the narrator hear in the darkness?

- a) A drumbeat
- b) A bell ringing
- c) A flute played
- d) A whisper

Ans: c) A flute played

22. Which are the household gods mentioned in the poem?

- a) Female members of the family
- b) Male members of the family
- c) Ancestral spirits
- d) Hindu deities

Ans: b) Male members of the family

23. The use of 'household gods' is a stringent criticism of

- a) Colonialism
- b) Patriarchal society
- c) Capitalism
- d) Caste system

Ans: b) Patriarchal society

24. What does the word "prow" mean?

- a) The back of a ship
- b) The pointed front part of a ship
- c) The middle deck
- d) The sail's edge

Ans: b) The pointed front part of a ship

25. Meena Alexander is "undoubtedly one of the finest poets of contemporary times." It is the opinion of

- a) The Hindu
- b) The Times
- c) The Statesman
- d) Poetry Magazine

Ans: c) The Statesman